

General Knowledge ***Ancient History***

STUDY NOTES

Kushanas



Post Maurya - Kushanas



- The **Kushanas** were a **Central Asian tribe** originating from the **Yue-Chi Confederation**.
- They gradually established their dominance in **Gandhara, Kabul Valley, and the Indus Basin**, expanding their empire into **India and Central Asia**.
- Their reign marked significant cultural, religious, economic, and artistic transformations, shaping ancient Indian history profoundly.

Key Rulers of the Kushana Empire

King	Reign	Contributions
Kujula Kadphises I	15 CE - 64 CE	United the Yue-Chi tribes, established the Kushana empire and issued Roman-inspired gold coins.
Vima Kadphises II	64 CE - 78 CE	Expanded the empire to Mathura and the Indus basin ; issued large quantities of gold coins; a devotee of Shiva .

Kanishka I	78 CE - 105 CE	Patron of Mahayana Buddhism ; convened the Fourth Buddhist Council ; ruled from Purushapura (Peshawar) and Mathura .
Vasudeva I	Early 3rd century CE	The last significant Kushana ruler; witnessed the decline of Kushana power under his reign.



Kanishka I: Key Contributions

- **Expansion of the Empire:** His empire spanned from **Central Asia** to the **Ganges valley** and from **Khorasan** to **Varanasi**.
- **Religious Patronage:**
 - **Mahayana Buddhism** became prominent under his reign.
 - He built **Buddhist stupas** and **monasteries** across the empire.
- **Fourth Buddhist Council:** Organized the council in **Srinagar**, Kashmir, presided by **Vasumitra**, which marked the division between **Mahayana** and **Hinayana Buddhism**.
- **Art and Architecture:** Promoted the **Gandhara** and **Mathura** schools of art.
- **Devputra Title:** Adopted the divine title "**Devputra**" (Son of God), highlighting the divine nature of kingship.



Administration of the Kushana Empire

Administrative Structure

- **The division into Satraps:**
 - The empire was divided into **Satrapies (provinces)**, each governed by a **Mahakshatrapa** (chief satrap), a military governor.
 - **Mahakshatrapas** acted both as **administrators** and **commanders** of the military in their regions, ensuring control over distant territories.

Administrative Unit	Officer	Role
Satrapy (Province)	Mahakshatrapa	Chief military governor and administrator
Districts	Dandanayaka / Mahadandanayaka	Semi-military officials, responsible for local governance
Villages	Gramika / Padrapala	Village headmen, responsible for tax collection and law enforcement

Village Administration

- **Village Headmen:**
 - **Gramika** and **Padrapala** were responsible for:
 - **Collecting taxes** and dues from the villages on behalf of the king.
 - **Maintaining law and order**, and addressing **criminal activities** in their areas.
- **Local Governance:**
 - The **village-level governance** system ensured **decentralized control** over rural areas.
 - The system allowed for a **smooth tax collection process** and **efficient administration**.

Dual Hereditary Rule

- The Kushanas practiced **dual hereditary rule**:
 - **Two rulers held power concurrently**, sharing administrative responsibilities.
 - This **dual authority** helped in maintaining **stability** over the vast empire.

Military Administration

- The **Mahakshatrapa** had control over the **military** in their region.
- **Military Officers**:
 - **Dandanayaka** and **Mahadandanayaka** were key military officials.
 - They managed **security, enforcement, and military operations** across the regions.
 - The **satraps** also played a crucial role in the **defense of trade routes**, ensuring smooth movement of goods along the **Silk Route**.

Coinage and Economy of the Kushanas

- **Coinage**:
 - Issued **gold, silver, and copper coins** in large quantities.
 - Coins featured **Greek, Hindu, and Buddhist deities**, reflecting religious tolerance.
 - Promoted trade by adopting **Roman coin standards**.

Metal	Purpose	Deities/Icons Featured
Gold Coins 	Trade	Shiva, Buddha, Greek gods like Zeus
Silver Coins 	Regional trade	Depictions of Kushana rulers

Copper Coins	Daily use	Images of temples and local symbols
		

- **Economic Contributions:**

- Controlled **Silk Route**, facilitating **Indo-Roman trade** and generating toll revenue.
- Promoted **agriculture**, with irrigation systems in **Afghanistan and Pakistan**.
- Imported **silk and spices**; exported **gold, precious stones, and ivory**.

Religion and Society under the Kushanas

- **Mahayana Buddhism:** Flourished with **Kanishka's patronage**, leading to the spread of Buddhism to **China and Central Asia**.
- **Hindu Influence:**
 - Rulers like **Vima Kadphises** were devotees of **Shiva**.
 - Some Kushanas also supported **Vaishnavism**.
- **Religious Tolerance:**
 - Coins depicted **multiple deities**, showing the **pluralistic society** under the Kushanas.
 - **Stupas and temples** for different faiths were constructed throughout the empire.

Scientific and Literary Contributions of the Kushanas

- **Sanskrit Literature:** **Buddhacharita** by **Ashvaghosha**, a biography of Buddha.
- **Astronomy and Astrology:** **Greek influences** introduced terms like **horoscope**.
- **Medical Advancements:** **Charaka**, the father of **Ayurveda**, was patronized by **Kanishka**.
- **Other Works:** **Kamasutra** by **Vatsyayana** was composed during this period, reflecting societal norms and values.

Three Schools of Art

Feature	Gandhara School	Mathura School	Amravati School
			
Theme	Predominantly Buddhist	Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain deities	Jataka tales and Buddha's life
Style	Realistic , Hellenistic influence	Indigenous , bold, and muscular	Narrative art , intricate reliefs
Material	Blue-grey stone	Red sandstone	White marble-like stone
Key Patrons	Kushanas	Kushanas	Satavahanas, Ikshvakus
Locations	Gandhara, Bامyan	Mathura, Kankalitila	Amravati, Nagarjunakonda
Characteristic Features	Buddha depicted with Greek drapery and wavy hair	Robust figures with Indian motifs	Depictions of Buddhist stories in carvings

Impact of the Kushana Empire

- **Political and Military:**
 - Introduced **satrap governance** and **military governorship**.
 - Controlled key **trade routes**, expanding influence across **India and Central Asia**.
- **Economic:**
 - Boosted **Silk Route trade**; issued **gold coins** that promoted commerce.
 - Established **irrigation systems** to improve agricultural productivity.

- **Religious:**
 - Patronized **Mahayana Buddhism**, spreading it to **Central Asia**.
 - Promoted **religious tolerance**, depicted in their coinage and art.
- **Art and Culture:**
 - Sponsored the **Gandhara and Mathura schools of art**.
 - Influenced Indian **literature, medicine, and astronomy** through foreign contacts.

Decline of the Kushana Empire

- **Vasudeva I** was the last prominent ruler, and after his reign, the **Kushana Empire gradually declined**.
- The **Sassanians** overthrew the Kushanas in **Central Asia**, while **Indian territories fragmented** into smaller kingdoms.
- Despite their decline, the **Kushanas left a lasting legacy** in **art, religion, and governance**, influencing subsequent Indian dynasties.